always gives everything. I wanted to be the tough little *boereseun*.

What did this mean?

It meant giving every ounce of energy to every task at every opportunity, and, more than that, being *seen* to give every ounce of energy to every task at every opportunity. It meant getting hit painfully on the end of the finger during a fielding practice and not wincing, not complaining, not missing a moment before diving for the next catch.

It meant being happy to face the fast bowlers in the nets, where the bounce was unpredictable and where the ball would usually be whistling past your ears or crunching into your ribs; it meant never dodging the challenge, saying I would bat the next day or saying I would rather take some throw-downs in the middle.

Being tough, being brave, being determined, always coming back for more, always finishing the session, never complaining, getting hurt and carrying on, getting hurt again and carrying on again – through these actions, I wanted to earn the respect of senior players such as Smith, Kallis and Boucher ... and, in the years to come, this was how any talented youngster coming into the Proteas squad would earn respect from me.

So the squad flew down to Port Elizabeth and, early on the morning of Friday, 17 December 2004, drove from the hotel to St George's Park to play the first day of the first Test against England. The South African selectors had picked two young players to make their Test debuts – one a young batter from Bela-Bela called De Villiers, the other a long-haired fast bowler from Phalaborwa by the name of Dale Steyn.

Just as we had played our first-class debuts together 14 months before, so Dale and I made our Test debuts on the same day. It was going to be another special occasion, particularly because my parents had travelled all the way from home and were sitting in the main grandstand alongside Derick Kuün, my friend from school who was keeping a promise we had made to each other.